

Chapter 110-1

Liang Wanwan had indeed cried for a long time last night. When she looked in the mirror after waking up early, she was startled by her own eyes.

Even when she went out to buy breakfast, she avoided people.

Sad emotions are most easily stirred up in the loneliness of deep night. She had cried her fill before falling asleep.

Before falling asleep, she was still thinking: From now on, I shouldn't like Chen Mian anymore.

But the first thing she did upon waking up early in the morning was instinctively reach for that sketchbook, just like usual. Only after flipping through the pillow did she suddenly remember—she was at her sister's home.

And her sketchbook had already been washed by Liang Xinran.

By that biological sister she had only just met.

The two of them looked quite alike, but Liang Wanwan hated being compared.

Especially for Qiu Zimin, who felt tremendously guilty toward the biological daughter who had just been brought back from that poor, remote place. She looked at her through a thick filter, which made Liang Wanwan—the biological daughter who had always been by her side—seem insignificant.

When Liang Wanwan thought about this, she couldn't help but cry again.

Only after crying did she carefully go wash up.

Now, eating breakfast with Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu, the two of them were very quiet—somewhat like eating in the school cafeteria.

After finishing the meal, Liang Wanwan got up to clean up, but Liang Shi took over. "You rest. I'll do it."

Liang Wanwan responded with an "oh."

She continued sitting on the sofa with Xu Qingzhu, chatting about movies. Some of her attention had been diverted.

But no matter how great Yang Shuyan was, she couldn't completely offset the sadness of losing Chen Mian's sketchbook.

Liang Wanwan lowered her eyes, seemingly looking earnestly at Yang Shuyan's poster, her whole person emanating a restrained, melancholic air.

Xu Qingzhu glanced at her thoughtfully a few times. She didn't offer to give Liang Wanwan the poster that Yang Shuyan had specifically given her. Instead, she asked: "Is there any personalized autograph you'd like?"¹

Liang Wanwan raised her head, her expression startled. She asked in disbelief: "Are you asking me?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded. "Yes. I can't give you this set, but the next time I see Yang Shuyan, I can help you get a personalized autograph."

She had heard that fans really loved these.

For example, her younger sister Xu Qingya.

And this was the only way Xu Qingzhu could think of to comfort her.

Liang Wanwan hesitated for a moment before saying somewhat embarrassedly: "If it's not too much trouble, I'd like the line—'How can one withstand the fierce evening wind.'"²

Xu Qingzhu asked: "Is that from that poem?"

"Mm." Liang Wanwan said: "I really like that line."

Xu Qingzhu agreed.

After Liang Shi finished cleaning up the kitchen and came out, Xu Qingzhu had already changed and was ready to go to work.

Liang Shi asked Liang Wanwan what she planned to do today. Liang Wanwan said she was going back to school—she had classes in the afternoon.

Liang Shi was worried about her condition and hesitated, wanting to keep her for another day. But Liang Wanwan let out a soft breath and showed a smile. "I'm really fine."

You could tell she hadn't fully recovered, but she was much better than last night.

After confirming with Liang Wanwan multiple times, Liang Shi finally said: "Then I'll take you to school later."

Liang Wanwan nodded and said okay.

She had always been quiet and wasn't particularly close to Liang Shi.

Being together now, they naturally didn't have much to say.

Liang Shi still wanted to see Xu Qingzhu off to work, but Xu Qingzhu waved the keyring on her finger. "I'll go by myself."

Liang Shi stood at the entryway. Xu Qingzhu braced herself against the shoe cabinet as her feet slipped nimbly into her high heels. She said to her quietly: "Rest for a bit, then take Wanwan."

Liang Shi saw her out the door and stood at the entrance for a while. Only after Xu Qingzhu got on the elevator and left did she close the door.

But when she turned around, she found Liang Wanwan staring at her without blinking.

Their eyes met.

Liang Wanwan was the first to lower her head. She looked a bit strange.

Liang Shi took the initiative to ask: "What's wrong?"

Just now, Liang Wanwan's gaze had contained a hint of longing, as well as curiosity and shock —altogether a very complex look.

Liang Wanwan instinctively shook her head, but after a moment she said: "Jie, just now you....."

She paused, her tone carrying a hint of disbelief: "You looked like a Waiting-Wife Stone."³

Liang Shi: "?"

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1. "To 簽" (To qiān) refers to a personalized autograph where the celebrity writes a specific message "To [fan's name]" along with their signature, making it a unique keepsake for that particular fan. ⇐
 2. "怎敵他晚來風急" is a famous line from the classical Chinese poem "声声慢" (Shēng Shēng Mǎn / "Slow, Slow Tune") by the renowned Song Dynasty poetess Li Qingzhao (李清照). The full line describes the poet's deep sorrow and loneliness. The phrase roughly translates to "How can one withstand the fierce evening wind," expressing a sense of vulnerability and melancholy. The character "晚" (wǎn, meaning "evening/late") in the line shares the same character as in Liang Wanwan's name (梁晚晚), giving it personal significance to her. ⇐
 3. "望妻石" (Wàng Qī Shí, "Waiting-Wife Stone" or "Husband-Watching Rock") refers to a famous rock formation in Chinese folklore. According to legend, a faithful wife stood watching and waiting for her husband's return for so long that she turned to stone. It has become a symbol of devoted, longing love. Liang Wanwan is teasing Liang Shi for looking like she was longingly watching Xu Qingzhu leave. ⇐

Chapter 110-2

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Liang Wanwan had actually never believed that Liang Shi would change, nor did she believe this marriage between her and Xu Qingzhu was genuine.

She had essentially grown up watching Liang Shi's back.

For as long as Liang Wanwan could remember, Liang Shi had never been a purely good person.

It was even hard to say she was a good older sister.

When they were in school, other people's older sisters would chat and laugh with their younger sisters, sharing fun things and good food together.

But she and Liang Shi never did that.

Their schools weren't far apart, and they were often picked up and dropped off in the same car. But whether on the way to school or on the way back, Liang Shi never talked much with her. Occasionally her gaze was gloomy, and her expression was cold, making people afraid to approach.

Liang Wanwan was timid to begin with and often kept her distance from her.

The deepest impression in her memory was when Liang Shi had stood up for her before.

That was something Liang Wanwan had never expected.

For a long time, she had felt that her older sister was as good as nonexistent.

But she never expected that one day she would hear Liang Shi coldly say to someone: "Do you want to die? Touching my little sister."

From that moment on, Liang Shi finally occupied a place in her heart.

However, most of the time they didn't talk. Even though they had each other on WeChat, they wouldn't chat much.

If they ran into each other at home, they would take detours to avoid each other. If they really came face to face, Liang Wanwan wouldn't even call out "Jie."

Liang Wanwan truly understood what Liang Shi used to be like.

She was a jerk.

Liang Wanwan felt that everyone who played with others' feelings was a jerk.

She had seen the women around Liang Shi change every few days. She had also seen her going in and out of high-end clubs. Once, out of curiosity, she even went to a well-known bar in Haizhou City.

That bar really wasn't a decent place, but Liang Wanwan truly hadn't expected Liang Shi to do that in public.

The woman's fabric was basically all concentrated around her lower abdomen.

To Liang Wanwan, it was a very shameful thing, yet that woman had an expression of enjoyment.

And Liang Wanwan saw Liang Shi's profile.

Her clothes weren't the slightest bit disheveled, even though she was clearly doing something that would make anyone blush just from watching.

Yet Liang Shi had no expression. Those eyes held nothing but bottomless indifference.

Because of that scene, Liang Wanwan didn't talk to Liang Shi for a long time.

In Liang Wanwan's view, Liang Shi was two-faced, a walking contradiction.

The contradictory thing about Liang Shi was that she constantly flitted among flowers without ever falling for anyone. Yet back then, she could argue fiercely with the family over wanting to marry Xu Qingzhu.

Back then, Liang Wanwan hadn't believed it.

She thought Liang Shi was simply coveting Xu Qingzhu's beauty and would lose interest once she got bored.

People like Liang Shi, just like Cheng Ran, had no true heart.

The first time Liang Wanwan saw Xu Qingzhu and Liang Shi standing together, that was exactly how she felt.

Liang Shi was even cold toward Xu Qingzhu. Those eyes were still gloomy and without warmth, and that face showed no emotion.

But unexpectedly, from last night until now, the two of them gave her the feeling that they were like a couple passionately in love.

No matter what they did, they would glance at each other. They spoke in gentle, soft voices, dyeing this small house with an ambiguous warmth.

They clearly hadn't said anything excessive or done anything excessive, yet it always made people feel like they were in a greenhouse. Even standing on the side watching their exchanged glances felt sweet.

Compared to the Liang Shi she had seen at the bar before, this person now had more gentleness and warmth of everyday life.

She didn't know if it was something Xu Qingzhu had brought to her.

Last night, Liang Wanwan originally hadn't planned to look for Liang Shi. But when she unconsciously walked onto the Yujiang Bridge, the river wind blew directly at her, making her shiver from the cold.

She suddenly remembered what Liang Shi had once said to her: "No matter what, I'm still your older sister. I'm definitely more reliable than outsiders."

That was after Liang Shi had stood up for her. When she saw her afterward, she still had that same cold expression.

Liang Wanwan hadn't understood at all and asked Liang Shi why she had done it.

Liang Shi had said that sentence.

Especially since it involved Chen Mian, Liang Wanwan had contacted her.

Many people knew of Chen Mian, but none of them knew that there was some connection between Liang Wanwan and Chen Mian.

But this connection was something Liang Shi had given her.

Liang Wanwan really wanted to talk to someone about Chen Mian. But when she made the call and faced Liang Shi, all she could do was complain with grievance: "She washed Chen Mian's sketchbook."

Yes, for her, it was nothing more than a feeling that couldn't be spoken aloud, that could only stay in the depths of her heart.

She hadn't seen Chen Mian for so long that she had almost forgotten what Chen Mian looked like.

Now, suddenly seeing how Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu interacted with each other, she once again remembered Chen Mian's figure.

Chen Mian liked to wear black shirts. Her figure was straight and proper, looking especially elegant in black shirts.

Her face wasn't particularly striking, and her eye shape was ordinary. But the mole at the corner of her eye added a touch of allure to her eyes, making her unforgettable at first sight.

Liang Wanwan held a cup of hot water in her hands, her hands resting on the cup. She lowered her head to blow away the rising steam, her voice earnest: "Jie, you have to treat Sister Qingzhu well."

Liang Shi was completely confused.

She had no idea that in such a short time, Liang Wanwan's mind had gone through such a brainstorm.

Faced with Liang Wanwan's words, Liang Shi could only go along with it: "She's my wife. Of course I'll treat her well."

Liang Wanwan smiled: "You'd better."

This was the first smile she had shown since seeing her last night.

Liang Shi's heart relaxed a little. At least she wasn't looking gloomy the whole time like before.

Liang Wanwan had a reserved personality and wouldn't actively make requests of Liang Shi. After staying overnight, she even felt guilty. With nothing to do at home in the morning, she started helping with cleaning, but Liang Shi wouldn't let her do any of it.

Besides, there wasn't much to do around the house anyway.

Liang Shi cleaned the house diligently. For such a small place, she cleaned up as she went along, keeping the house spotless at all times.

Later, seeing that she was truly restless, Liang Shi found a stack of A4 paper and handed it to Liang Wanwan. "You can draw for a while. The river view here is quite nice."

There were no sketching pencils at home, so Liang Wanwan used a ballpoint pen instead.

But what she drew wasn't the river view—it was Liang Shi.

Chapter 110-3

Liang Shi would soon be joining the production crew to film. Recently, Zhao Ying had been so exhausted that she rarely posted on her Moments anymore.¹ One day at three in the morning, she even sent Liang Shi a WeChat message saying she still hadn't wrapped up for the day. She also sent Liang Shi a photo of the night scene at the set and asked: 【Why did I decide to enter this industry back then, and even drag you along?】

The next day, Liang Shi woke up and replied: 【Because of passion, I guess.】

Zhao Ying instantly replied: 【I just got back to the hotel. I've discovered I'm more passionate about sleeping.】

A few seconds later, another message came: 【Passion and all that can go die. I'm going home to do my dreaming!】

This sentence looked familiar. As Liang Shi read it aloud, she ended up singing it.

Only then did she realize it was a non-mainstream hit song that had been popular during their student days.²

Different worlds, same youth.

It amused Liang Shi for quite a while.

But it would soon be her turn. Because this drama's director was strict and was aiming for awards, and in order to meet the platform's broadcast schedule, they had to finish filming within a month and a half—and it was still a massive 36-episode production.

It was too difficult.

In situations like this, working through the night was completely normal. It required all staff members to tough it out together.

Liang Shi said she understood, but her body might not be able to hold up when the time came.

She used to film night scenes often and stay up late too. But after transmigrating here, Xu Qingzhu's schedule was too healthy—she basically had to be asleep before 11 PM every night. Except for that period when she first joined Minghui, but even then, Liang Shi hadn't stayed up with her and had maintained a normal schedule.

After more than two months of regular sleep, now whenever she stayed up late, she would be dead tired the next day.

Her body couldn't support her returning to that day-and-night-reversed lifestyle.

She estimated she would have to tough it out when she first joined the crew.

But the most important issue right now was still the script.

When the director let her come back before, he had said that if she had time, she should memorize all her lines. Otherwise, if they started filming and she kept getting stuck because she couldn't remember her lines, he would really lose his temper.

Liang Shi had agreed without hesitation.

She was free now, so she began memorizing her lines. The most important thing was to sort out the character relationships and scenes, then memorize based on context.

She was very serious when memorizing, and to avoid disturbing Liang Wanwan, she memorized silently.

What Liang Wanwan drew was her earnestly reading the script.

Her long brown curly hair was casually tied back with a black hair tie. She wore light-colored loungewear, with the long sleeves rolled up to reveal her forearms. On her wrist was a silver, sparkling bracelet. Her eyes were lowered as she earnestly read the pages densely covered with text, a black pen held between her slender fingers.

Her fingers were slender with distinct knuckles, yet they looked soft.

The pen casually spun between her fingers. The cold sunlight from outside refracted in, making her whole person appear gentle and beautiful.

Like a quiet ink wash painting.

Liang Wanwan picked up her pen and began to draw. The ballpoint pen naturally affected her performance, but she didn't draw any less seriously just because it was a ballpoint pen.

On the contrary, in the quiet space, she could concentrate better. Once she entered the state of drawing, it was like switching to sage mode³—she would only be immersed in her own world.

Her strokes were almost flawless.

After finishing the drawing of the earnest Liang Shi, she placed it face-down to the side and took a fresh blank sheet of paper.

Liang Wanwan wanted to draw a picture of Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu together, because it was too beautiful.

Two beautiful people standing there was already a painting in itself.

But as she thought about it, she felt every scene was equally beautiful, making it difficult to choose which one to draw.

She pondered for a long time in her mind, conflicted and hesitant.

But the moment her pen touched the paper, that scene flowed from her mind onto the page.

It was the scene from this morning when the two of them stood at the entryway. Xu Qingzhu slightly tiptoed and leaned in, wiping away a smudge from Liang Shi's collar.

Xu Qingzhu's expression was serious. Liang Shi lowered her head to look at her hair ends—just one centimeter more and she could have kissed her.

It was the perfect ambiguous distance.

In that moment, the two of them seemed to automatically form their own little world.

No one could intrude.

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1. "朋友圈" (Péngyou quān, Moments) is the social feed feature on WeChat where users can post updates, photos, and videos that their friends can see—similar to Facebook's timeline or Instagram's feed. ↵
 2. "非主流" (fēi zhǔliú, non-mainstream) refers to an alternative youth subculture popular in China during the late 2000s, characterized by emo-style fashion, dramatic hairstyles, and emotional/melodramatic music and content. "Non-mainstream hit songs" from that era often had dramatic, emotional lyrics. ↵
 3. "賢者模式" (xiánzhě móshì, sage mode) is internet slang referring to a state of extreme calm, clarity, and focus—often used humorously to describe the peaceful, zen-like mental state one enters when deeply concentrated on something. ↵

Chapter 110-4

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Liang Shi hadn't deliberately gone to look at Liang Wanwan's drawings—she just caught a glimpse from the corner of her eye when she stood up.

She discovered that Liang Wanwan was drawing her and Xu Qingzhu. Even with a ballpoint pen, it had a wonderful sense of atmosphere.

Liang Shi was surprised by her drawing talent and also by her keen observation.

This scene was nothing more than an ordinary, everyday moment for her and Xu Qingzhu, yet Liang Wanwan had drawn it with such aesthetic beauty.

Liang Shi silently glanced at it, put away the script, and then went back to the room to change.

It was getting late.

She needed to take Liang Wanwan out for a meal and then send her back to her dormitory.

However, she didn't feel comfortable disturbing Liang Wanwan while she was drawing.

But when she finished changing and came out of the room, Liang Wanwan had also already changed. She had neatly folded Xu Qingzhu's pajamas that she had worn last night and placed them on the headboard of the guest bedroom bed.

The blanket in the guest bedroom was also spread out very neatly—it didn't look like anyone had slept there at all.

It had to be said that Qiu Zimin really was good when it came to education.

Whether it was Liang Xinzhou, Liang Xinhe, or Liang Wanwan, they all had their own strengths, and these strengths were completely capable of outweighing their flaws.

Yet Liang Wanwan was still wearing the same thin shirt from yesterday.

Haizhou City today wasn't any better than yesterday—the temperature was still close to below zero. When Xu Qingzhu left this morning, she had already put on a thick wool coat.

Liang Shi's clothes were too big and wouldn't fit Liang Wanwan.

The small-sized clothes Xu Qingzhu had bought could barely fit Liang Wanwan. So Liang Shi sent Xu Qingzhu a message asking if she had any thick clothes suitable for Liang Wanwan to wear.

After sending it, Liang Shi thought Xu Qingzhu might take a long time to reply, but unexpectedly Xu Qingzhu replied instantly.

【Look in the closet yourself. She can basically wear any of them.】

Xu Qingzhu's reply had no warmth to it—a completely business-like tone.

But Liang Shi was used to it. When she was at work, her answers were always brief and to the point. Then Liang Shi suddenly remembered the matter Liang Xinzhou had asked about last night, so she added: 【Oh, and remember to ask about the Xu Kang situation.】

After saying that, she quickly added: 【Go ahead and be busy. I won't disturb your work anymore.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【.....】

A moment later, Xu Qingzhu sent a message: 【Teacher Liang, Sally says you're being a bit green tea.】¹

Liang Shi: "?"

Liang Shi didn't understand and was greatly shocked.

Xu Qingzhu specifically quoted her message in reply: 【Sally says you're subtly implying that I'm neglecting you because of work, and that you're jealous of my work.】

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi opened the closet while pressing her phone to send a voice message. Her tone was helpless yet amused: "Tell Sally that she's the green tea one."

Liang Shi said: "I simply wanted to tell you to focus on your work. I'm not jealous over this."

A few seconds later came another voice message: "Who would get jealous over something like this? Work is important business. I'm not that unreasonable."

After saying this, Liang Shi put her phone aside and rummaged through Xu Qingzhu's closet.

She took out a light blue wool coat from Xu Qingzhu's closet, along with a fleece-lined sweatshirt. Then, thinking about the thin jeans on Liang Wanwan's legs, she looked for fleece-lined pants that Xu Qingzhu hadn't worn yet.

This weather really did call for fleece-lined pants.

Xu Qingzhu's belongings were arranged very neatly. Her undergarments were all placed together, separated into compartments.

But Liang Shi didn't know where she kept them, so she could only search through them one by one.

As it turned out, the first thing she found was lingerie.

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They were uniformly white in color, and quite sizeable.

Liang Shi's earlobes turned slightly red. Just as she was about to put them back, she noticed one with a rather unique style.

She looked closely. That piece of lingerie had pitifully little fabric, and the lace trim was very wide. She silently pictured Xu Qingzhu's chest shape in her mind—this strip of lace trim should cover about half.

If worn, it would probably have a hazy, misty beauty, like the moon veiled in fog.

Just thinking about it made Liang Shi's ears burn intensely.

She immediately put it back and fanned herself with her hand, trying to fan away that flutter and heat.

She quickly grabbed the things she needed, then went out to hand them to Liang Wanwan.

Liang Shi let out a soft breath, but before she could fully exhale, Liang Wanwan suddenly asked in confusion: "Jie, is it really hot in here?"

Liang Shi: "....."

"No, it's not." Liang Shi answered instinctively.

Liang Wanwan looked bewildered: "Then why is your face so red?"

Additionally, Liang Wanwan reached out and placed the back of her hand on Liang Shi's face. "And it's so hot."

Liang Shi: "....."

"It's not." Liang Shi was somewhat flustered. Hearing her words made her feel extremely embarrassed inside. Afraid that if she said any more, her face would get even hotter, she immediately urged: "Hurry up and go change. We're going out to eat."

Liang Wanwan said: "Oh."

But as she was holding Xu Qingzhu's clothes and entering the room, she suddenly seemed to realize something. She turned around and looked at Liang Shi with a knowing gaze: "Jie, you didn't happen to see something you shouldn't have, did you?"

Liang Shi: "....."

She hurried toward the kitchen in a fluster, her voice very small as she answered: "What could I possibly have seen that I shouldn't have?"

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1. "绿茶" (lǜ chá, green tea) or "绿茶婊" (green tea bitch) is Chinese internet slang for someone who appears innocent and pure on the surface but is actually manipulative and scheming underneath. Being called "green tea" implies someone is being passive-aggressive or playing mind games while pretending to be considerate. ↩

Chapter 110-5

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Before taking Liang Wanwan back to school, Liang Shi first brought her to Liang Xinzhou's place.

When Liang Xinzhou saw his two younger sisters, his expression remained indifferent as always. He only asked about their daily affairs, mostly about their studies and health, reminding them to eat properly and such. After finishing the routine questions, he finally asked Liang Wanwan: "What exactly happened last night?"

At the mention of last night, Liang Wanwan's heart felt like it was bleeding, but she still told Liang Xinzhou everything.

After finishing, she asked cautiously: "Da-ge, I didn't cause you any trouble, did I?"

Because Liang Xinzhou was the eldest brother and much older than them.

Many things were shouldered by Liang Xinzhou at the front. Sometimes when Liang Wanwan did something wrong, Qiu Zimin would even complain to Liang Xinzhou about it.

Let alone this time.

Because first there was Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe collectively leaving home, and then she had directly slapped Liang Xinran.

Qiu Zimin would definitely be furious and call to scold Liang Xinzhou. She might even falsely accuse Liang Xinzhou of instigating the younger siblings.

Liang Xinzhou curved his lips into a smile, carrying a hint of mockery, but quickly restrained it.

He said flatly: "What trouble could you cause me? I didn't answer their calls."

He hadn't argued or defended Liang Wanwan either.

What's done is done. Was he supposed to make Liang Wanwan stand there and let Liang Xinran slap her back?

That was impossible.

Because of one Liang Xinran, after hitting two sons, they were going to hit the youngest daughter too?

That would truly be a joke.

Liang Xinzhou would never let such a thing happen no matter what.

For something to make Liang Wanwan angry enough to hit someone, she must have been absolutely livid. That slap—Liang Xinran deserved it.

When Liang Xinran had first returned, Liang Xinzhou still had a sliver of warmth toward her. He thought that if she had good character, she could be raised at home, or they could give her a large sum of money and have her live elsewhere.

The whole family shouldn't fall apart because of her return. After all, by blood, she was still his biological sister.

But that was just a tiny bit of warmth within his wariness, which couldn't withstand her causing trouble again and again.

The moment Liang Xinzhou moved out of the house, he knew that if they didn't send Liang Xinran away, the family's collapse was inevitable.

So he might as well go all in.¹

He had come out with this mindset, though he had forgotten about his younger siblings.

Looking at all these conflicts happening in their family, calling them coincidences seemed far too coincidental.

And Liang Xinzhou had never believed in such coincidences.

Liang Shi then asked how things were going with Xu Tong's side and whether there were any new leads.

Liang Xinzhou hesitated for a moment, then brought down a stack of documents from the study upstairs. These were materials he had traced and uncovered yesterday.

He had discovered that Xu Tong's father, Xu Kang, had once been in contact with a woman named Zhang Yangning, and this woman was from Taozhi Village—the same place as Liang Xinran.

Zhang Yangning was an HR at an advertising company, five years older than Liang Xinran, and had graduated from an ordinary second-tier university.²

But for Taozhi Village, this was quite an impressive accomplishment. However, both her parents had passed away, and she had also been raised by her grandmother, who had long since passed as well. She was essentially alone in the world with no ties left in Taozhi Village, yet she would return to the village two or three times a year.

Liang Xinzhou had someone call the village chief of Taozhi Village. According to him, Zhang Yangning was much older than Liang Xinran, and he hadn't heard of any interaction between the two. Moreover, back then, Zhang Yangning's mother and Liang Xinran's mother were famously at odds, and because of that, the children from both families didn't speak to each other either.

Furthermore, Zhang Yangning was known in the village for being arrogant—probably because she was one of the few college graduates from the village. Every year when she came home, she drove a new car, dressed immaculately, and as soon as she arrived, she would hole up in her renovated house and basically never go out.

She would stay in the village for a few days during New Year and then leave, never even greeting the neighbors.

At the end, the village chief even complained that he didn't know why she came back every year—she didn't even know to bring flowers when visiting her parents' graves.

Liang Shi quickly skimmed through the documents. They contained Xu Kang's resume. His previous company was also a design firm in the industry, but not very well-known—far inferior to Haiwei. However, the fact that any company would hire him after he had stolen company secrets was already quite remarkable.

But the reason he only worked at the second company for one month was that the company belatedly discovered the real reason he had left Haiwei, so they fired him.

Because he had stolen company secrets, he had to compensate Haiwei Jewelry 1.2 million yuan.

For him, that was an enormous sum. And according to what Liang Xinzhou knew, the secret he sold had only fetched one million.

After everything, he was actually out 200,000 yuan.

It was also because he had worked at Haiwei Jewelry for quite a long time that the company showed him some mercy and didn't take him to court or have him imprisoned.

But this incident had dealt Xu Kang a significant blow and turned his life upside down.

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1. "破釜沉舟" (pò fǔ chén zhōu) is a Chinese idiom meaning "to break the cauldrons and sink the boats"—referring to the historical story of a general who ordered his troops to destroy their cooking pots and boats after crossing a river, leaving no option for retreat. It means to be determined to succeed by eliminating all means of retreat; to go all in or burn one's bridges. ⇐
 2. "二本" (èr běn, second-tier) refers to China's university ranking system. Universities are categorized into tiers, with "一本" (first-tier) being the most prestigious and "二本" (second-tier) being less selective but still respectable institutions. ⇐

Chapter 110-6

Following this lead, Liang Xinzhou discovered that Xu Kang and this Zhang Yangning had been in contact six months before he was fired from Haiwei Jewelry.

Liang Shi was surprised: "So you suspect Zhang Yangning is connected to Xu Kang's theft case?"

"Not only that." Liang Xinzhou said: "My intuition tells me there must be something between Liang Xinran and Zhang Yangning."

Liang Shi furrowed her brows slightly: "You mean the incident with Ling Dang was deliberately orchestrated by Liang Xinran?"

Liang Xinzhou was silent for a long while before he said in a deep voice: "There's no substantial evidence."

Liang Xinzhou was a very cautious person. He wouldn't accuse anyone of something without substantial evidence.

But investigating this matter thoroughly would be very difficult.

These kinds of tangled, intertwined relationships were easily overlooked.

Liang Shi said helplessly: "Then what about Ling Dang's situation? We're just going to let it go like this?"

She still remembered the little girl crying with hiccupping sobs, looking as aggrieved as a little rabbit. If they just let it go like this, it would definitely leave a knot in the child's heart.

Moreover, since that day's incident, Ling Dang had become especially sensitive.

If it had been before, when Ling Dang accidentally pushed Sheng Yu and Sheng Yu bled, Ling Dang would definitely have gone up to comfort Sheng Yu, saying sorry while telling her not to cry. But that night, Ling Dang only dared to stand there and quietly say sorry, panicked, helpless, and scared.

That wasn't the Ling Dang that Liang Shi knew.

Liang Xinzhou paused slightly. His gaze was contemptuous, yet his tone was arrogant: "How could that be possible?"

Liang Shi perked up: "Oh?"

"This evening after school, you go pick up Ling Dang." Liang Xinzhou said: "Take her directly to the old residence. Liang Xinhe and I will return to the old residence before you arrive."

His tone was calm, but his words carried absolute certainty.

Liang Shi felt that he was like a safe harbor, giving people a sufficient sense of security.

Just hearing him say this, Liang Shi felt fired up and immediately agreed.

After leaving Liang Xinzhou's place, Liang Shi took Liang Wanwan back to school.

The Media University wasn't far from the Medical University, but the teaching buildings were much newer. The students coming and going at the entrance were particularly energetic and had an artistic air about them.

Liang Shi reminded Liang Wanwan not to be too sad. If there was an opportunity later, she would help her ask Chen Mian for an autograph.

Liang Wanwan thought about it, then shook her head and said it wasn't necessary. She also mentioned that Xu Qingzhu had promised to get her Yang Shuyan's personalized autograph.

Liang Wanwan smiled: "Maybe it's time I started liking someone else."

These words sounded like she was consulting with herself. Her smile was tinged with a hint of bitterness.

Liang Shi had no other choice but to accept this.

But after Liang Wanwan left, she took out her phone and sent Xu Qingzhu a message: 【You promised Wanwan a personalized autograph from Yang Shuyan? Can you actually get one?】

The implication was—come to me, I can get it.

Liang Shi had checked—in this drama, she had scenes with Yang Shuyan, so she would definitely be able to see her.

Meanwhile, Xu Qingzhu didn't have much contact with Yang Shuyan anymore. The only connection would be through Lin Luoxi.

But asking someone for a favor over this matter wasn't ideal.

So Liang Shi consciously took this matter upon herself, feeling that she was the only one who could do it.

But two minutes later, Xu Qingzhu sent over a photo.

On it was clearly Yang Shuyan's handwriting—

To Liang Wanwan

How can one withstand the fierce evening wind.¹

By Yang Shuyan

The handwriting was wild and flowing, but Liang Shi could recognize every character.

Just as Liang Shi was about to ask for more details, she received a call from an unknown number. After only a brief hesitation, she answered: "Hello?"

After receiving so many unknown calls meant for the original owner, Liang Shi felt like she was working in customer service.

But there was no response from the other end—only soft, slow breathing.

Liang Shi was sitting in the car, isolated from the noisy world outside, so she could hear it clearly.

After a moment, she asked again: "What do you need?"

The other end of the phone finally spoke. The voice was cold and detached, completely different from before: "Where are you right now?"

It was Gu Xingyue!

Liang Shi was startled: "I'm at the entrance of the Media University. What's wrong?"

"I need to see you." Gu Xingyue said: "If you have time, let's meet at Gulang Pavilion."

Liang Shi asked: "Right now?"

"Yes, I only have half an hour." After saying this, Gu Xingyue paused for a moment. "By the way, do you know Chen Mian?"

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1. "怎敵他晚來風急" is the same classical Chinese poetry line from Li Qingzhao's "声声慢" (Slow, Slow Tune) that Liang Wanwan had requested. The character "晚" (wǎn, meaning "evening/late") in this line shares the same character as in Liang Wanwan's name (梁晚晚), giving it personal significance to her. ↩